LT 8000 – Foundations of Instructional Technology

Week 15 IDT Case Study

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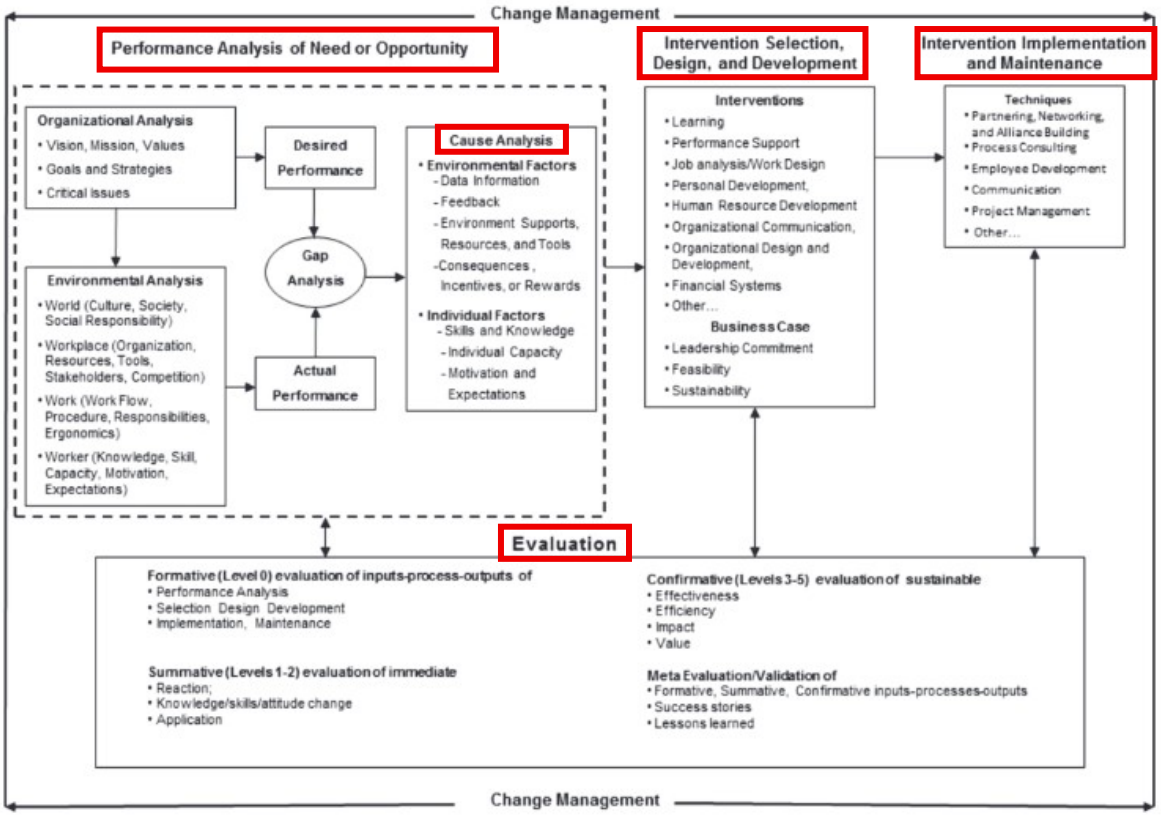
Title: The Human Performance Technology Model Applied to a University Library's Work Efficiency

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Introduction

The case study covers "The Human Performance Technology Model Applied to a University Library's Work Efficiency" (Wells, Stanley, & Martin, 2014), which explores the challenges faced by a university library's administrative system. This research applied the Human Performance Technology (HPT) model to address operational performance issues within the university's library administrative team. The HPT is a performance improvement framework that emphasizes identifying performance gaps, analyzing their causes, and designing interventions aligned with the organizational context. The HPT model includes a five-step process, shown in the following diagram:



Source. Fundamentals of Performance Technology: Optimizing Results Through People, Processes and Organizations by D. M. Van Tiem, J. L. Moseley, & J. C. Dessinger, 2012. Used with permission from ISPI/Wiley.

FIGURE 1. ISPI HUMAN PERFORMANCE TECHNOLOGY MODEL

Adapted from Wells, Stanley, and Martin (2014)

- **Performance Analysis**:

This step focuses on identifying gaps between desired and actual performance.

- **Cause Analysis**:
  This phase identifies the root causes of the gaps using tools like a fishbone diagram or other analytical methods.
- **Intervention Selection, Design, and Development**:
  This step focuses on selecting suitable solutions for the gaps identified during the analysis.
- **Implementation and Maintenance**:
  This step focuses on implementing chosen interventions and ensuring their sustainability over time.
- **Evaluation**:
  In this phase, the intervention solutions are assessed to determine their outcomes.

Many believe that training is essential for closing gaps in all types of academic settings. However, this case study highlights how HPT can be used for interventions beyond training to boost workplace performance.

Overview of the Case

The case was discovered at a public library in the United States, called "Racine Library", to maintain anonymity. Its mission was 'to inspire, nurture, and satisfy intellectual and cultural curiosity'. The library's administrative team, which included the librarian, executive assistant, budget officer, and facilities coordinator, was responsible for supporting the library's operations and managing related activities.

The team was highly motivated and skilled at completing their regular tasks. However, they faced communication and environmental issues that affected their efficiency and workflow. This supports Reiser and Dempsey's (2018) observation that "*performance problems are often caused by environmental constraints rather than individual deficiencies*." Since the library was located in a busy area, constant interruptions disrupted their focus. Staff and other business-related meetings were often canceled or poorly organized, and they received overwhelming emails filled with redundant and duplicate messages that lacked prioritization. These challenges made it difficult for the team to finish tasks on time, often causing them to work from home.

Therefore, the library leadership recognized that these performance issues not only affected productivity but also the professional practices the team needed to maintain in the workplace. To address these issues, the author used the HPT model.

A comprehensive analysis was carried out using interviews, observations, and environmental scans. The consulting team followed the step-by-step HPT model. They started by conducting stakeholder interviews and reviewing existing data to support the environment. Then, they performed organizational, environmental, gap, and cause analyses.

The analysis identified four key findings:

1. Constant interruptions in the workplace
2. Ineffective meetings
3. Poor communication and
4. Incomplete or Delayed work

The consultants performed a gap analysis to identify these issues by comparing expected and actual performance.

TABLE 1 ADMINISTRATIVE TEAM PERFORMANCE GAPS

DESIRED PERFORMANCE	GAP	ACTUAL PERFORMANCE
Time/quality	Approximately 40 hours per week for the administrative team as a whole	Work taken home
Meetings productive, not canceled	Productivity/cancellations	Meetings unproductive or canceled
Reduce unnecessary communications by 85%	Inefficient use	Excessive time in email, lack of effective communication
Locate team in same, protected space	Separated/90% foot traffic	Team location: separated, heavily trafficked

Adapted from Wells, Stanley, and Martin (2014)

Solutions Implemented

Based on the data collected, three solutions were proposed using the HPT model's intervention step:

- **Relocation:** Moving the office space was crucial to reduce interruptions and distractions. It allowed the team to focus better in a quieter environment. This is a cost-effective approach.
- **Organizing Meetings:** It is essential to review current meeting practices and improve future meetings by carefully assigning tasks, setting clear agendas, and confirming the Librarian's availability. It was recommended that participants not crucial to the meeting receive updates through the minutes. Another suggestion was to reduce meeting frequency from bi-monthly to monthly.
- **Email Management Job Aid:** This recommendation was again cost-effective and had an immediate impact. It focused on strategies like stopping distracting automatic emails and scheduled email checks, filtering important senders, and using the "4 Ds" (Delete, Do, Delegate, Defer). Also, face-to-face communication is preferred for topics needing immediate attention.

A feasibility analysis, although not a formal step in the ISPI HPT model, assessed intervention items based on three key concepts: **Time**, which indicates how quickly implementation can occur; **Cost**, which evaluates the monetary implications relative to benefits; and **Value**, which gauges ease of adoption. Each concept is scored on a scale of 1-3, with lower scores representing better solutions.

TABLE 3 FEASIBILITY ANALYSIS

CONSIDERATION (ESTIMATED OR PROJECTED)	TIME—T (1 LEAST TO 3 MOST)	COST—C (1 LEAST TO 3 MOST)	VALUE—V (1 MOST TO 3 LEAST)	TOTAL C + S + V
ENVIRONMENT—LONG TERM				
Relocate upstairs	3	2	1	6
ENVIRONMENT—SHORT TERM				
Block main thoroughfare	2	1	1	4
Limit access to restrooms	1	1	2	4
Reroute traffic temporarily	2	1	2	5
MEETINGS				
Eliminate when possible	1	1	2	4
Consolidate as appropriate	2	1	2	5
Upload an agenda	1	1	1	3
Delegate committee member to manage meeting minutes	2	2	2	6
Individuals should run their own meeting	2	2	1	5
Evaluate frequency of all meetings and necessity	2	2	1	5
Reschedule at university librarian's convenience	1	1	1	3
EMAIL				
Schedule a set time to check email	2	1	1	4
Turn off jingle and pop-up distractions	1	1	2	4
Make a rule for important email senders only (such as the boss)	1	1	1	3
Start at the top	1	1	2	4
Quick steps	1	1	2	4
Go mobile	1	3	2	6
The 4 Ds of decision-making model	2	1	2	5
Training as appropriate	3	2	2	7

Adapted from Wells, Stanley, and Martin (2014)

Outcomes

The primary outcome of this case study was highlighted in the client's feedback and the consultant's reflections. The most noticeable result was relocating the administrative office, which eliminated unwanted interruptions and distractions while working and created a more productive workspace.

The immediate results included:

- Minimizing interruptions through the office relocation
- Improving workflow as staff completed tasks during office hours
- Reducing meeting cancellations and clarifying discussions by restructuring meetings and consolidating agendas

Although not explicitly stated, staff probably saved time by using Email job aids and implementing scheduler checks and 4Ds strategies.

Overall, the client appreciated the feasibility analysis and was open to implementing the recommendations.

Implications

The case emphasizes important lessons about using the HPT model in practice:

- A thorough performance analysis is necessary to identify gaps and their root causes. Without this step, solutions would only address symptoms rather than causes.
- The feasibility assessment is now included in the HPT model.
- The client recognized the issues and was willing to follow through with the recommendations. After reviewing the report, the client felt motivated to update the existing processes.

Finally, many people believe that HPT is effective in corporate settings, but it is equally helpful in academic environments, mainly for administrative or other performance-based tasks.

References

- Wells, N. L., Stanley, A., & Martin, F. (2014). The human performance technology model applied to a university library's work efficiency. *Performance Improvement, 53*(3), 14–21.
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- Robinson, D. G., & Robinson, J. C. (2008). *Performance consulting: A practical guide for HR and learning professionals*. Berrett-Koehler Publishers.